will keep their doors open for one and all round the clock. I once sat with Lalu Prasad in his bathroom while he was shaving, while Mamata Banerjee will SMS you at 2 a.m. with a news point!

Rahul, it appears, prefers the corporate 9 a.m. to 6 p.m. working style, ill-suited to a political world where every party member should have a right to your time. An old Congressman who knew Rajiv Gandhi well draws a fine contrast. ‘Rajiv liked to take his Sundays off, but the rest of the week, he would work a punishing schedule, often till late in the night. Rahul is ready to work hard, but wants to switch off all too often. He doesn’t understand he is not working in a foreign bank but is in politics in India.’

Rajiv was also a naturally warm and open-hearted person. Rahul, though, tends to be reserved and lacking the easy charm of his father. I had met Rajiv once in 1990 at a function organized by the then South Mumbai MP Murli Deora. His ready smile had floored the audience within minutes. Rahul, I was told, could have mood swings. ‘He can be gracious and attentive one moment, and seem rude and stand-offish the next,’ is how a Congress MP described his behaviour. Apparently, when Rahul once visited Chennai for a Youth Congress function, a senior Congress leader from Tamil Nadu suggested he might wish to pay a courtesy call on M. Karunanidhi who was then chief minister and a Congress ally. ‘I am here for a Youth Congress function, I can meet him some other time,’ was the terse reply. He eventually never met the DMK chieftain.

Unlike Rajiv, who was blamed for relying on a tiny cabal for political advice, Rahul does seek wider counsel. He would, for example, as regularly consult Sam Pitroda, the flamboyant technology adviser to Rajiv, as he would a university academic or a business leader. ‘He is much brighter than you think,’ Pitroda once told me, a shade defensively.

But the truth is, Rahul has miserably failed to build a political team of substance. He gave important posts to relatively minor politicians like Madhusudhan Mistry (general secretary in charge of UP) and Mohan Prakash (general secretary in charge of Maharashtra and a former Janata Dal leader). ‘These are netas who can’t win a seat in their home states—how will they win some other state for us?’ a senior Congress MP told me